

MUSIC TO THE EARS: Magoo leading her orchestra



The Unseen Symphony

The success of a visually-impaired orchestra proves that great vision has nothing to do with eyes

■ By Prerana Thakurdesai

The first time Manju Magoo performed at a music show at Mumbai's Radio Club, she returned Rs 300 out of the Rs 900 the organisers paid her. The visually challenged Magoo didn't think she deserved "so much" money for her singing. A year later, Magoo's musical orchestra, comprising nine other visually challenged musicians, was rewarded Rs 1 lakh at a function where the audience was spellbound by their performance. Divyasur, her orchestra, has come a long way from singing bhajans at small gatherings to participating in the *Antakshari* show on television.

Talent and need are the only criterion to be a member. "We have a screening process, and select only those who have a good classical music base and also need money," says Magoo, who has done her master's in music and is pursuing post graduation in finance. Incidentally, all those who are part of Divyasur are graduates. The point of difference between them and other orchestras, featuring the blind, is the variety of songs they can sing. "At any point of time, we have at least five concept shows ready. Whether it is Hindi, Marathi, Punjabi and Gujarati songs or bhajans or classics, we are always prepared," says Ajay Antani, the only visu-



ally-able member in the group.

Each member plays with proficiency. Give them a new song and Adimalu Anderajaya won't take more than five minutes to pick it up on his keyboard and Donald Koli would be strumming chords on his guitar. For others, blindness may be a handicap, but for the members of Divyasur, it only means less

distractions and more concentration on their music. Beams Koli, "I have played with other handicapped groups, but here, there's a lot of *dhamaal*. We make music without ever arguing or fighting."

For Magoo, the journey of putting together a "cricket team", as she fondly refers to her group, wasn't simple. "I was tired of asking people to help the blind, till I decided, we must help ourselves," says Magoo, who has played judge on *Star Voice of India*. As the only woman managing an orchestra, Magoo says many have tried to discourage her, but she has emerged successful. The major problem the orchestra faces relates to procuring instruments. Hiring is expensive and buying is out of the question, so the donation of instruments would be ideal. Future plans include the group tying up with a Dubai-based company to perform on a monthly basis. "Foreigners have a better attitude towards the handicapped," says Magoo. A lesson we all need to learn. ■